What Little I Wouldn’t Do

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What Little I Wouldn’t Do

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Phainon arrived in Castrum Kremnos under the harmless pretense of a casual visit, hoping to convince the nation’s cold, untouchable Crown Prince to join the Flame Chase Journey. Several failed attempts later, he somehow ends up getting absolutely railed by him instead.

Diplomacy’s a delicate art.

Notes

Behold, the fruit of my all-nighters, age gap for day 4!!! Oh gosh this set me back so much when I wrote it considering it’s nearly 20k (Hence why again still working on day 7) but it was so fun to write😭

Also for context the clothes Phainon was wearing are the clothes from that video where he was I think drinking wine?

See the end of the work for more notes

The towering white marble gates of Kremnos caught the last of the afternoon sun, their polished surface gleaming like bone. Phainon had been standing in front of them for what felt like hours now, though it was probably closer to twenty minutes. Twenty minutes of polite smiles, casual pleasantries, and answering the same questions phrased six different ways.

His back ached. His neck was starting to prickle under the heat of the sun. The guards still hadn't budged.

The one leading the questioning was a thick-necked man with a scowl that looked carved from stone, his leather breastplate catching dull flashes of light as he shifted. He hadn't asked for Phainon's name again—he already knew that. What he wanted was a reason.

"So then," the guard drawled, his gaze flicking over Phainon's borrowed Kremnoan clothes with thinly veiled suspicion, "state your purpose in Castrum Kremnos."

Phainon smiled, as if this weren't the sixth time he'd been asked a version of that same thing.

"Just passing through," he said lightly. "Thought I'd see the sights. No official business."

The guard stared at him. A long, heavy kind of stare, the kind meant to make a man sweat. Phainon held the look, kept his expression relaxed, though he could feel the itch of tension in his jaw.

He wasn't sure if it was the clothes Cipher had gotten for him, or if he just didn't wear the Kremnoan look well enough. Maybe it was the fact that, even dressed like this, something about him would always scream outsider.

The guard opened his mouth, clearly gearing up to press further, maybe deny him outright, when another soldier laid a hand on his shoulder. A brief, silent exchange passed between them. The guard's jaw ticked. He made a low sound in the back of his throat, then reluctantly stepped aside.

Phainon smiled, dipping his head a fraction. “Much appreciated.”

And just like that, he was in.

He stepped past the gates, the cool shadow swallowing him whole, and let out a breath he hadn’t realized he’d been holding.

Wasn’t so hard.

He hadn’t even made it ten paces into the city before the stares started.

Phainon kept his stride easy, his chin lifted just so, a casual little half-smile playing on his mouth. The streets of Kremnos stretched wide and clean ahead of him, paved in pale stone that flashed white in the sun. Vendors called out their wares in the distance—bronze, spice, cured meat, armament—their voices carrying clearly through the heat. But it wasn’t the goods they were hawking that caught attention now.

It was him.

Eyes tracked him from under helmets and behind market stalls. Quick glances, sharp and assessing. Some bold, some subtle. All the same look: foreigner.

Didn’t matter that he was dressed for the part. Cipher had made sure of that. She’d cobbled together a passable Kremnoan outfit in record time, pulling in favors from traveling tailors and gods-knew-who-else. A toga-styled garment, loosely draped over one shoulder and cinched at the waist. The inner fabric a deep, rich purple—too rich—and a few sharp, deliberate cuts along the hem and sides gave it a touch of easy, languid nobility. Exactly what Aglaea had warned him not to wear.

The gold laurel wreath adorning his hair probably wasn’t helping.

Neither was the delicate gold anklet around his left leg, shaped like a twisting vine in bloom. Cipher had laughed when she’d pressed it into his palm. *“For luck,”* she’d said, but he knew her too well. Luck had nothing

to do with it. She wanted a favor. And now, thanks to this little ensemble, he probably owed her two.

Aglaea had nearly lost composure over it. Muttering about the Kallion Oath and blood-soaked streets. *"One thread out of place in that city and we risk war,"* she'd snapped, smoothing her hair with a hand that, for the first time since Phainon had known her, trembled faintly at the wrist.

Still. He'd worn it. He was here.

And it was immediately clear how poorly it landed.

Too fine a drape. A touch too perfumed for Kremnos, a city that valued strength above all. Here, men's clothes (usually) clung close to the body, practical and built for bloodshed or training grounds. No indulgent silks. No suggestive cuts. No gold wreaths unless you'd taken a city for the gods.

So yes—they recognized him. Or at least, they suspected.

The Deliverer of Okhema might've left his formal regalia behind, but the face was the same. The city hadn't forgotten, even two years after the ink dried on the Kallion Oath—a fragile peace held together by Aglaea's intervention and the Titan's own mercy.

Phainon just smiled through it. As if he didn't feel the weight of every stare.

"Well… that could've gone worse." he muttered under his breath, letting the sarcasm warm his throat.

And he kept walking.

He was here for a casual visit.

That was the line, anyway. Just a simple trip, a friendly neighbor stopping by to see the famed war coliseums and blood gardens.

And if you believed that, you were a damn fool.

Everyone in Kremnos knew better. Hell, *he* knew better. The only person deluded enough to pretend otherwise was Aglaea, and even she had the decency to grit her teeth when she said it out loud.

The truth hung in the air as thick as the heat rising from the marble streets.

The Flame Chase Journey loomed on the horizon. And like it or not, Phainon *needed* that prince.

The Crown Prince, Mydeimos. A royal born with gold in his veins, a war god's own lineage and a blade that never dulled. They'd sent envoys. Invitations. Summons. Cipher even floated a few carefully worded bribes through less official channels. Every message was met with the same reply:

No.

And it didn't help that only a handful of years before, Kremnos and Okhema had been at war—a brutal, bloody conflict older than Mydeimos himself, fought by men Phainon barely remembered and kings now long dead. No peace treaty, no matter how delicately brokered, erased that.

Coming here officially would've been a disaster. If Okhema's Deliverer strolled in carrying a formal request to drag their heir halfway across the world for a suicidal pilgrimage, it'd be a matter of days before Queen Gorgo and King Eurypon had his head displayed on a pike on top of Nikador's statue. They hadn't been particularly impressed with him during his last brief encounter at Aglaea's side either—Phainon still vividly remembered Gorgo's cool, imperious gaze and Eurypon's dismissive grunt when he spoke.

So Aglaea had come up with a workaround.

A casual visit.

And why him? Out of all the well-bred nobles and born diplomats Okhema could've sent?

Simple. Phainon was the most disarming of them all—too ‘simple’ to be a real threat, too charming to outright refuse. And, more importantly, there was history. The kind that stretched far enough back Phainon honestly doubted Mydeimos remembered it. Still. Even if he didn’t…

At least he’d get to see the prince again.

He let that thought settle in his chest as he ducked into a small open-air shop lining the street. Baskets of bronze trinkets and leather amulets hung from poles, swaying in the heat. The vendor barely spared him a glance, busy carving a symbol into a flat piece of stone. Phainon wandered over, offering one of his smiles that usually softened stony expressions.

He picked up a small, spear-shaped charm—cast in dull iron, rough around the edges, but something about it caught his eye.

“How much for this one?” he asked, Kremnoan tongue rolling a little too smoothly off his lips.

The old woman looked up. Her gaze landed on the gold laurel at his temple, the purple flash of his inner garment, and then his face. The moment stretched.

Too long.

Phainon’s smile wavered.

“…A gift, perhaps,” he offered, placing the charm back down and brushing his fingertips over a set of carved runes nearby. “Is this Nikador’s mark? Or—”

The entire shop shifted.

A man at the next stall turned his head. A girl carrying a basket of figs paused mid-step. The old vendor stiffened, her weathered mouth flattening into a line.

It hit him a beat too late.

Ah.

He wasn’t supposed to touch that. Or maybe it was what he’d said. Or how he’d said it.

“…What?” Phainon blinked, still smiling, confused.

A muttered string of clipped, annoyed Kremnoan spat at him like a curse. He caught *foreigner, soft-palmed, gold-bleeder.* Several heads turned. Someone at his shoulder grunted a threat in his ear he couldn’t quite catch.

And then—a firm hand on his shoulder, shoving him toward the street.

Phainon stumbled out into the sunlight, laughing under his breath as a sharp voice barked after him. He wasn’t fluent enough to translate the whole thing, but he was pretty sure it boiled down to *get lost.*

Well.

He dusted himself off, glancing up at the marble spires in the distance.

Looked like he had his work cut out for him.

By the time the sun slid low enough to stain the white stone streets in gold, Phainon had managed to secure a place to stay.

It wasn’t much—a modest guesthouse tucked between a weaponsmith and a dye shop, the kind of place respectable Okheman diplomats would sneer at and Cipher would call *authentic*. The matron who ran it hadn’t been thrilled to rent him a room, her gaze lingering on his laurel a little too long, but money was money. And Kremnos respected a man who paid in gold without haggling.

The room was small. Clean, though. A narrow cot, a basin, and a single shuttered window that overlooked a narrow alley where young soldiers laughed and drank until the moon came up.

Phainon dropped his satchel onto the cot, rolled his shoulders, and let out a breath.

Alright. Attempt one. The Coliseum.

Why the Coliseum? Well—it was one of Kremnos' grandest, most famed public arenas. A towering ring of marble and iron where men bled for glory and the gods' favor. Half the city gathered there by sunset for duels, war games, and Nikador-only-knows what else (Get it?).

If he was going to pose as a harmless traveler, might as well hit the top attractions. And it didn't hurt that he'd overheard a vendor mutter earlier about *the young prince attending the evening bouts.* Apparently, the Crown Prince frequented the place. Often.

Phainon grinned to himself as he fastened the golden anklet around his calf again, pulling the draped folds of his garment into place.

"See, Aglaea," he murmured, glancing at his reflection in the tiny mirror propped against the wall. "This counts as blending in."

Even if half the street had stared daggers into him when he passed, and an old man spat at his feet for the *perfumed foreigner stink.*

Whatever.

Coliseum it was.

Getting there was a trial all its own.

Kremnos wasn't a city built for strangers. The streets curved and climbed like the ribs of some ancient beast, narrow alleys that abruptly ended in sheer drops or opened into sprawling squares. Every man on the road seemed to have somewhere urgent to be—and no patience for someone blocking their path. Phainon spent more time dodging shoulder checks and cold stares than actually walking.

By the time he reached the outer edge of the Coliseum, the sun hung low in the sky, throwing long shadows across the gleaming marble. The structure

was immense, a massive open ring of stone and iron, white columns stretching into the clouds, the distant ring of weapons clashing carrying out over the walls. Banners in crimson and black snapped high above, emblazoned with Nikador's sigil.

Phainon let out a low breath. *Finally*.

He approached a vendor hawking drinks outside the entrance—cups filled with some dark thing. Phainon flashed his easy smile and held up a finger. The man narrowed his eyes, named a price at least double what it should've been, and Phainon didn't even flinch. He tossed the coins over. Not worth fighting.

The drink was vile. Bitter and thick with something that clung to the back of his throat like wet bark. He coughed. A group of men leaning against a pillar nearby snorted and muttered under their breath, not bothering to lower their voices.

Phainon just offered them a lazy two-fingered salute and kept walking.

Inside, the air was dense with the metallic tang of blood. The stands were packed—a writhing sea of spectators draped in dark cloaks, some already shouting bets or jeering down at the arena. Sunlight struck off a thousand bare blades, the ring of steel and the roar of the crowd mixing into something that made Phainon's skin prickle.

He let his gaze lift to the Royal Box—elevated above the masses, shadowed beneath thick red banners. Perfect view of the sand-stained floor below. But it was empty.

Phainon's brow furrowed. *Was he wrong?*

After all that?

But the roar of the crowd surged suddenly, a wave of noise, and he caught the glint of bronze helms and bare chests clashing below. The match had already started.

He cursed under his breath.

Well, you're here now.

Rolling his metaphorical sleeves up, Phainon squared his shoulders and prepared to wade into the wall of people for a front-row view. *If I bleed out before I see the prince, my ghost better haunt this damn place.*

It took hell and a half to get to that seat.

Phainon had braved elbows, shoulders, insults muttered just loud enough for him to hear, and what might've been a half-hearted attempt to trip him on the stairs. At one point, a wiry old man nearly jabbed him in the gut with a walking stick when he tried to squeeze past. He offered his brightest, most apologetic grin and sidestepped the jab. Kremnos didn't make anything easy.

But damn it, he got the seat.

Wedged between two burly spectators who barely acknowledged his existence, Phainon settled in, the coarse stone warm beneath him from hours of sun. From here, he had a decent view of the arena, close enough to make out the dust kicked up by every step, the rippling muscles, the sharp glint of knuckles connecting with bone.

He expected anything. Two brawny men, some hulking champion, a pack of wild animals. But no.

No, of course not.

Why?

The Crown Prince himself was in the pit.

Phainon blinked. His jaw nearly dropped.

There he was—Mydeimos of Kremnos, bare-chested save for a simple wrap across his knuckles, sweat slicking his hair to his brow, golden eyes cold as struck coin as he drove his fist into another man's jaw. The crack was

audible even from here. The other fighter stumbled back, blood flying, but Mydei didn’t hesitate. He moved like a panther—no hesitation.

Phainon exhaled a low, almost incredulous laugh. *Well, my lucky day.*

He’d come to chase a ghost of a maybe-past, and instead landed himself a front-row seat to watch the very prince he needed beating the living hell out of someone.

And gods, he’d grown up.

Taller now. Shoulders broad with that hard-cut soldier’s build Kremnos prized. Face sharper—handsome in a way that felt almost unfair, like something carved, all sculpted angles and those impossibly beautiful eyes. Phainon felt something in his chest twinge, his smile softening despite himself.

Good for him.

He should’ve left it at that. Watched, taken mental notes, maybe waited for the fight to end and figured out how to talk to him later.

But then—then those gold eyes turned.

Phainon swore, for a second, that Mydeimos sensed something. In the middle of a brutal match, with sweat on his brow and a crowd roaring in his ears, the prince’s gaze snapped up. Directly to him.

Their eyes met.

Gold to blue.

Phainon felt it like a gut punch.

Time stuttered for a moment. The roaring of the crowd dulled. Phainon’s grin faltered, a flicker of heat climbing the back of his neck. Because Mydei didn’t just look. He *stared*. That sharp, unflinching stare that pinned a man in place and made him feel like his skin didn’t quite fit right.

Phainon swallowed.

And then—to make matters worse—Mydeimos' gaze dropped.

Not to the sands. Not to the bloodied man still swaying on his feet before him.

To *him*.

To the draped folds of Phainon's toga-styled garment, the rich purple catching in the light like something obscene in a city built on discipline and earth-tones. The laurel wreath caught a glint of sun. The faint curve of the gold anklet flashed when he shifted his weight.

Phainon caught the prince's brow twitch.

Small. Barely there. A flicker of something unreadable that pulled at the edge of his mouth.

A rare, sharp spark of embarrassment prickled at the back of Phainon's neck.

Yeah… alright. It's too gaudy. Should've gone with the duller one. The gray. Or that ugly tan Cipher tried to push on me.

He tugged at the edge of the fabric self-consciously. But then—and gods above, why *always* then—Phainon did the dumbest possible thing.

He raised a hand.

Just a little.

A casual, idiotically cheerful little flick of his fingers. The kind you gave to a neighbor you barely knew, or a child passing in the street. And then—because apparently one bad decision wasn't enough—he tacked on a thumbs up.

Why.

Why in the gods' names—

Mydeimos didn't react right away. His face didn't so much as flinch.

But Phainon saw it.

That momentary stone-cold hardening of those gold eyes. The twitch of a brow, almost imperceptible. And then—pointedly, without a word—the prince turned his head away.

And immediately drove his fist harder into his opponent. A brutal, teeth-rattling hit.

Phainon blinked.

Well. Alright then.

Maybe not a great idea.

What he didn't know—what he couldn't possibly guess, because his own stubborn, blithely casual perspective refused to let him—was that down in that arena, Mydeimos was, in fact, quietly losing his mind.

Because the man he'd spent years—*years*—secretly, miserably crushing on since childhood had just appeared like some half-drunk sun god, in far-too-rich Kremnoan garb, collarbone and forearms out, hair damp from heat and sticking to his brow.

And then *waved* at him. And gave him a damn thumbs up.

Like he was still that scrawny, bloodied kid clutching a splintered practice sword and looking up at him like he was anything.

Phainon, of course, caught none of it.

He just leaned back in his seat, let out a low whistle, and took another sip of that awful drink.

“Huh,” he muttered, half to himself, watching as Mydeimos fought even harder now, each blow a little sharper, a little faster, a little more brutal.

The crowd roared.

The men on either side of him muttered something in irritation—something about foreign fools, and *watch where you smile, idiot*—but Phainon barely noticed.

He just grinned, one elbow slung over the back of his stone seat.

Lucky day, indeed.

The fight eventually ended with a final blow—Mydeimos driving his fist hard into the other man’s gut, sending him sprawling onto the blood-dusted sand. The crowd roared its approval, a guttural, rising sound that shook the air itself.

Phainon winced on the poor bastard’s behalf.

Well. That was that.

Mydeimos didn’t linger over his victory. He raised a hand—a simple, quick gesture of acknowledgment, palm angled toward the stands. It sent the crowd into fresh cheers, a low chant of his name rising and falling like a tide.

But not once did he look at Phainon again.

Not a flicker of a glance. Not a bat of his eyelashes. Nothing

Phainon let out a quiet, breathy laugh through his nose, shaking his head to himself.

Alright. Stonewalling me. Cute.

A little petty, maybe. But… cute.

It shouldn’t have stung. Really, it shouldn’t have. He wasn’t here for Mydei’s attention—not like that, anyway. He had a mission. Bigger things.

But that pointed cold-shoulder landed its blow cleaner than any fist.

Phainon rolled his shoulders, let it slide off. Or tried to.

The prince strode out of the arena, long strides carrying him through the sand archway without breaking pace as his guard fell in around him.

The crowd stayed, murmuring, buzzing with the aftershock of the fight.

Phainon took one last sip of his drink, made a face, and stood.

Time to get to work.

It took a small eternity and no fewer than three accidental elbow jabs to the ribs to make it through the congested stone passageways and down into the lower tiers.

He caught a glimpse—a flash of blonde hair—ahead.

There.

Without thinking, he started weaving his way through the press of people, half-raising his hand in a loose, casual wave. “Hey—”

A broad, armored figure stepped squarely into his path.

Phainon nearly collided with him.

The guard didn’t even look at him.

“Private audience,” the man grunted. “The Crown Prince doesn’t receive visitors without cause.”

Phainon’s jaw twitched.

Gods, it would've been so easy. So easy to let something slip from his tongue. A pointed quip, a half-smile paired with some remark about Kremnoan hospitality.

But Aglaea's voice hissed at the back of his mind: *One thread out of place in that city and we risk war.*

So.

He swallowed it down. Smoothed his face into something warm, genial, harmless.

"Of course," he said, all polite grace, and stepped aside.

But not before his gaze caught, just for a second, on the scene beyond the guard.

Mydeimos had slowed his steps. A small cluster of men closed in around him—not soldiers. Friends.

Phainon didn't need long to guess which one was *Hephaestion*. Broad-shouldered, bronze-skinned, laugh too easy, the kind of man whose hand clapped Mydeimos on the shoulder and earned, unbelievably, the faintest curl of a smile from the prince.

Phainon's gut twisted.

He looked away before it could settle.

Whatever. It didn't matter. This was a long game.

As he turned back toward the city streets, sun already starting to dip, Phainon sighed under his breath.

"Well," he muttered to himself, "attempt one was a learning experience."

Another sigh.

"Attempt two's where I reclaim my dignity"

And with that, he vanished into the crowd.

Attempt Two did not go better.

In fact, it might've gone *worse*.

Phainon, to his credit, tried. At least three times.

First time?

At the market square—easy, right? He figured maybe he could spot the prince doing something utterly mundane, like selecting olives or verbally decimating a fish vendor. What he got instead was a grizzled merchant barking *"Okheman's pay double"* before shortchanging him, and no prince in sight. Solid start.

Second time?

The sparring grounds. Word around town was that Mydeimos trained there at least twice a week. Phainon loitered by the fences, made small talk with a trio of soldiers (one of whom kept eyeing his clothes like he was a goat in silk), and waited.

The prince didn't show.

A kid offered to 'fetch him for a price.' Phainon paid.

The kid pocketed the coin and vanished.

Naturally.

Third time?

Desperation made a man creative. Phainon called in a handful of favors, slipped coin where it mattered, and managed to wrangle a formal audience. *Official, scheduled, documented.* Gods be good.

It lasted ten seconds.

Maybe twelve if you counted the time it took for Mydeimos to walk in.

And Phainon—exhausted, irritable, and fed up with the cold-shoulder act—opened with what in hindsight might not have been the best line.

“You’re really making this difficult, little prince.”

And for a flicker, just a fraction of a heartbeat, something happened.

A twitch.

A barely-there tension around the eyes.

A flare of something dark and utterly indecipherable.

And then?

Without a word, without so much as a goddamn blink, Mydeimos turned, gestured for the guards, and walked right the fuck out.

Phainon was left standing there in a cold, empty chamber, utterly bewildered and a little mortified.

He didn’t know what he’d done wrong.

Not really.

Not then.

And now?

Now this is where it landed him.

Smack dab in the middle of the palace throne room, looking down like a scolded schoolboy. The hall was towering—a vault of pale marble, iron standards hanging from the beams, every banner a crimson red.

And at the far end, seated like war gods judging the unworthy, were Queen Gorgo and King Eurypon.

Neither of them spoke.

Neither of them needed to.

The unimpressed look on their faces was a language unto itself.

Phainon sighed. Ran a hand through his hair.

Shit. He fucked up.

To his credit, he didn’t squirm.

Phainon sat with his back straight, hands resting loosely on his knees, and met their stares with a practiced calm he’d perfected over years of dinners and tense post-battle negotiations. He even managed a polite, if somewhat strained, smile.

Across the hall, Queen Gorgo sat with all the glacial elegance of a carved statue. King Eurypon was just behind her left side—looming.

The unspoken message hung in the room thick as fog: *We know why you’re here. And we don’t like it.*

Gorgo spoke first.

Her voice was soft. Cold as fresh-forged steel plunged in ice.

“I trust Castrum Kremnos has… met your expectations, Deliverer.”

Phainon inclined his head. “It’s a beautiful city, Your Majesty.”

She hummed. A small, humorless sound. “You seem to be making yourself quite comfortable in it.”

There was a flicker of amusement in her gaze, like she was daring him to play innocent.

Phainon thanked Tribbie in his head for making him study royal etiquette before he left Okhema. He knew better than to argue. Or apologize. Or offer

excuses. Kremnoans weren't fond of excuses.

"I'm grateful for your people's hospitality," he replied. "Even if I suspect the price of wine's doubled since I arrived."

Eurypon gave a low, dry snort at that. A fraction of approval, maybe. Or not.

Gorgo didn't smile.

"And yet," she went on, "I wonder what brings Okhema's Deliverer so far from his home."

"I'm not here in any official capacity," Phainon replied, as evenly as he could. "Just a casual visit."

He was careful not to glance at Eurypon. Or at the ceremonial axe leaning against the wall behind him.

"I see," Gorgo murmured. "And in your casual wanderings, you seem to find yourself… frequently in my son's path."

"That was never my—"

"Little prince has grown up, hasn't he?" Phainon blurted, then immediately bit down on the inside of his cheek.

Shit.

Too late.

The queen's brows arched. Eurypon let out a long-suffering sigh, one hand scrubbing over his jaw.

Phainon fumbled. "I meant—Crown Prince. Crown Prince Mydeimos. He's, ah—"

"Hopeless," Eurypon muttered, not to Phainon but to some far-off, exasperated god.

There was a weight to that word.

Something Phainon didn’t quite catch.

Gorgo studied him in silence for a long, heavy beat. Then—and maybe it was a trick of the light, maybe not—something in her expression softened. Just a crack. Not warmth. Resignation, perhaps.

“If it weren’t for my son’s… liking of you,” she murmured, almost to herself, “I’d have cleaved you in half by now.”

Phainon blinked.

“Pardon?”

But before he could puzzle that one out, Eurypon grunted. “You’re dismissed.”

Phainon didn’t argue. He stood, gave a crisp, shallow bow, and turned on his heel.

As he left the hall, he thought—not for the first time—that he might actually end up hanged before this trip was over.

Kephale help him, he still didn’t know what he’d done wrong.

Phainon was about ready to give up.

Today was the day of the Festival of Nikador—the grandest of Kremnos’ yearly rites. A day when warriors, veterans, and would-be heroes gathered in droves to pay blood and praise to the Strife God. When the streets thundered with drumbeats and the clang of sparring blades, and fire-eaters stalked between banners. A city of conquerors celebrating the ancient covenant of war.

You’d think, under those blood-red skies and amidst all that glorious chaos, this would be the perfect place for Phainon to mingle.

It was not.

He barely made it through the first hour before some swaggering local bruiser with more brawn than sense took offense to his *everything*. Phainon hadn't even said anything provocative. The man had just declared him *scum* and challenged him on the spot.

It was supposed to be a quick, harmless scuffle.

It wasn't.

Phainon ducked one punch, tripped the man by reflex, and the poor bastard landed face-first in a pile of red-dyed festival garlands.

The onlookers howled.

And just like that—he'd humiliated a local in public.

Result: minor notoriety, immediate price hikes, and a running tally of dirty looks. Everything cost thrice as much now. Ale, food, festival trinkets. He even caught one stallkeeper muttering *"Deliverer my ass"* under his breath.

Phainon sighed, massaging his temple. *Perfect*.

Well—if there was one good thing to come of this minor disaster…

"Ready to move to the next quarter?" a voice asked beside him.

He glanced over. The stranger was maybe a little older than Mydeimos, gentle

looking, sun-browned, with a crooked nose that had been broken once and a smile that looked far too amused by Phainon's entire existence.

Ptolemy, that was it.

They'd literally run into each other not long after the garland incident—Phainon half-distracted looking for a drink vendor that wouldn't triple-charge him, Ptolemy weaving through the crowd carrying some grilled

skewers. To his mild shock, instead of swearing at him, the man had recognized who he was. And instead of a challenge or a glare, Ptolemy had asked about Okhema.

Actual curiosity. A minor miracle.

They'd stuck together since.

In the space of an hour, Ptolemy had not only steered him clear of several pickpockets and a would-be knife duel, but also taken it upon himself to help locate one of Phainon's missing anklets. Somewhere along the way, it had come loose—and if Cipher found out he'd lost it in a festival crowd, Phainon would never hear the end of it.

The man even waved away the merchants charging him extra.

Phainon might've actually made his first friend in Kremnos.

It also didn't hurt that, walking beside Ptolemy, the dirty looks lessened and more than a few warriors gave him respectful nods.

Maybe this night wasn't a total loss after all.

Phainon spotted it like a man dying of thirst spotting an oasis.

"There," he muttered, eyes narrowing.

Sure enough—the damned anklet, gleaming faintly gold in the dirt, just beneath the edge of a merchant's stall piled high with spice baskets.

"Finally," he breathed, already moving.

"Wait, hold on—" Ptolemy called, but Phainon was already ducking through the crowd.

It should've been simple. Quick grab, a sheepish thanks to the vendor, back to drinking overpriced festival wine.

It was not.

The anklet glinted in the lamplight as someone's boot swung out, accidentally kicking it. It slid a few feet, clinking against a stone.

Phainon hissed a curse. "No, no, no—"

He made to follow, weaving past a pair of laughing women with painted faces. His fingers brushed it—only for a passing child chasing a paper wind-dragon to step right in front of him, the anklet bouncing away again.

"Oh, come on—"

It was absurd, really. A ridiculous, petty chase through a sea of bodies and firelight. At one point, the anklet rolled beneath a table where three warriors were deep in a drinking contest, sloshing their cups as they cheered. At another, a passing dancer's trailing sash knocked it back into open view.

It became a game of near-misses. Every time Phainon reached for it, someone would block his way—an elderly vendor waving roasted chestnuts, a priest of Nikador singing an old hymn, a pair of lovers not watching where they were going.

And then—because the gods had a sense of humor—a Droma came barreling through.

And of course—*of course*—its hooves struck the anklet, sending it skittering through the air like a coin flipped by fate.

It landed somewhere deep in the heart of a private, roped-off courtyard lit by hanging lamps. A space guarded by posted soldiers and clearly meant for the city's upper echelon.

Phainon stared, deflated. "You have got to be kidding me."

"Well," Ptolemy said, clapping him on the back. "At least it stopped moving."

Phainon groaned. "I am going to drown myself in the river."

"Not yet," Ptolemy grinned. "Lucky for you, I know the way. Follow me."

They slipped around the edge of the courtyard, ducking past a cart stacked with amphorae. Ptolemy exchanged a few quiet words with a guard, who rolled his eyes but let them through.

The exclusive space was quieter. The noise of the festival was dulled here, replaced by the soft hum of stringed instruments and the occasional low conversation.

And there was the anklet.

It had landed neatly at the base of a seated figure's feet. A man, busy tuning a lyre. His expression bored, until he glanced down at the little golden thing by his sandal.

Phainon was already raising a hand. "Apologies, I didn't mean—"

Before he could finish, Ptolemy's face lit up. "Peucesta!" he called.

The man looked up, and for the first time Phainon got a good look at him. Lean and sharp in the face, disinterested.

Peucesta arched a brow. Then—with the barest flicker of a smile—he twisted his foot, lightly kicking the anklet away.

It slid.

Phainon's jaw clenched. "You've got to be—"

He followed its arc with his eyes, about to say something sharp—and stopped dead.

Because it had landed by another pair of shoes.

Familiar ones.

Metallic, dusty from the arena sand. And above them—the tall, unmistakable figure of Mydeimos, standing in conversation with another man Ptolemy casually referred to as *Leonnius*.

Phainon’s throat went dry.

He hadn’t even realized the prince was here.

Mydeimos looked good. Unfairly so. The light caught in the stray strands of his hair, jaw set in a thoughtful line as he listened to Leonnius speak. His posture still and sharp, one hand resting against his hip, the other holding a cup of something red.

Phainon felt his stomach twist in a way he didn’t particularly like.

Peucesta let out a soft, flat *“Oops.”*

Phainon didn’t move.

Because Mydeimos was about to turn.

His gaze landed on Phainon.

A pause.

Then—the prince’s first actual word to him.

“…Deliverer?”

Phainon’s stomach dropped clean through the floor.

And because gods were cruel and he was *stupid*, his body moved before his brain caught up.

“Hey!” Phainon heard himself say, too bright, striding forward like they were old friends running into each other at a vineyard. “Nice to see you again—what a coincidence.”

And then—and may he be struck down by Nikador himself—Phainon reached out and clapped the prince on the shoulder.

It was awkward. It was so, *so awkward*.

Mydeimos stiffened.

Phainon, feeling his own soul leave his body, immediately bent down—snagging the damned anklet at the prince's feet in one swift motion.

"Anyway," he muttered, ducking his head, face burning as he backed up. "Got what I came for."

He made it two steps before Peucesta let out a long, low whistle.

Ptolemy visibly winced, rubbing a hand down his face.

Leonnius coughed into his cup, a sound entirely too amused to be polite. "You must be Phainon," he said at last.

Phainon grimaced, schooling his expression into something passable as charm. "The one and only."

Peucesta gave him a slow, lingering once-over, then snorted. "So you're the Deliverer, huh? Taller than you, isn't he?"

Phainon blinked, glancing between them. "Is… that relevant or…?"

He trailed off as Mydeimos's eye twitched again. The others exchanged glances. An inside joke. One Phainon wasn't in on.

And this would've been it, wouldn't it? His perfect window. The ideal opening to strike up a conversation, finally make his case, deliver his proposal, *anything*.

But no. No, his dignity was in tatters, and his soul was halfway down the river.

"I should probably—" Phainon began, edging back toward Ptolemy.

"Nonsense," Ptolemy grinned, entirely too cheerfully, clapping a firm hand between his shoulder blades and guiding him down into a seat nearby. "Let us help."

Phainon flailed mentally, awkwardly lowering himself onto the bench, still clutching the anklet like a lifeline. The table was suddenly very full of people he did not know and did not trust, except maybe Ptolemy.

And then nothing happened for a second.

The music played. A cup was refilled. Mydeimos hadn't moved.

Until Leonnius, not even glancing up from his drink, nudged out a booted foot and smacked it against the back of the prince's leg.

Mydeimos shot him a glare.

Leonnius raised a brow, the look he returned speaking volumes.

Get your shit together, boy.

Mydeimos sighed.

And then—to Phainon's utter horror—the prince crouched in front of him.

Phainon forgot how to breathe.

Because Mydeimos, silent and unreadable, reached out—took the anklet from his hand—and began fixing the clasp with careful fingers.

Phainon made a strangled sound in the back of his throat. His soul left his body. His soul *left*.

Not a single god in the heavens could help him now.

He finished fastening the anklet with a deft flick of his thumb, the clasp clicking into place. It was a small thing, but his touch had been careful—surprisingly so for a man who swung swords heavier than most livestock and had a stare sharp enough to flay bone.

Phainon cleared his throat, trying for light, a touch of old teasing.

"…Appreciate it, little prince."

No sooner were the words out than a shift ran through the air—one Phainon, oblivious, didn't catch.

The silence hit like a dropped blade.

Ptolemy, to his credit, didn't even pretend not to hear it.

"Damn," he muttered under his breath.

Mydeimos stilled.

Whatever flicker of warmth that settled in his eyes vanished so fast it might've never existed. The line of his shoulders tightened, and when he stood, it was rigid.

"I remembered I had business elsewhere," Mydeimos said—clipped and perfectly civil. And not looking at him.

He turned before Phainon could speak, before he could explain or laugh it off, or apologize, or gods, *anything*.

"Mydei, wait—"

But the prince was already walking, the crowd parting instinctively around him.

Phainon sat there for a heartbeat, stunned, blinking after him. The warm ache of embarrassment spread slow in his chest.

He didn't even realize someone else was approaching until the tall figure of Hephaestion stepped into view—having arrived just in time to see Mydeimos pass him with a short nod and a look of barely restrained frustration.

Hephaestion's brow furrowed, confusion flickering across his face. Then his gaze shifted to Phainon.

And in that moment, something passed between them.

A knowing clarity that hurt a little more than it should've.

It was too quick—the way understanding settled in Hephaestion's face. He didn't need to ask. He just *knew*, because it was Mydei.

Phainon shouldn't have cared. But a sour, inexplicable flicker twisted in his chest.

Hephaestion crossed his arms loosely. "He'll be in the gardens," he said, voice quieter than before.

Phainon didn't bother asking how he knew. He just swallowed hard and gave a curt nod, a silent thank you as he pushed himself to his feet.

And then, without another word, he moved after the prince.

Mydeimos remembered.

Gods, he remembered.

Years before he was Crown Prince. Before Kremnos' coliseums sang his name in blood and before Nikador's priests called him blessed. Before titles and duty. He was no more than a battered, half-dead boy with a broken sword in his hand and a dozen lifeless men at his feet.

A border skirmish, they called it. A footnote in a season's campaign log. To him, it was the first time he truly understood how fast men could die. How slow the hours felt after, the heat thick with the scent of blood and old copper.

He'd refused to leave them. The other survivors were already marching back to camp, but he stayed. Sprawled in a shallow ravine, thigh bleeding sluggishly, dirt in his mouth, heart clawing against his ribs. The weight of it was crushing—the failure, the loneliness.

And then the boy.

Older than him by some years—rough around the edges, sun-darkened skin, hands like he worked the earth. No insignia, no armor, just a simple sash and a dagger worn smooth by use.

He should have killed him.

Should have drawn the broken blade at his side, or called out a warning. But he didn't.

Because the boy crouched beside him, and spoke like they were already kin.

"That's a nasty scrape, little prince."

He hadn't said it like an insult. Not even mockery. Just easy, offhand familiarity, like it was a name Mydeimos had always carried. It rankled. It warmed. Both, somehow.

The boy—Phainon, though he wouldn't learn the name until later—cleaned the wound, tore strips from his own tunic, packed it with something bitter-smelling from a pouch at his belt.

When Mydeimos had tried to get up, to limp back to his men, the older boy had pressed a hand to his shoulder, steady but gentle.

"A dead prince can't avenge his men. Live long enough to scare them later."

And Mydeimos remembered the way it made his chest ache. How desperately he wanted to be that—feared, unbroken, worthy of his dead.

He'd stayed there with him. Not for a night. Not for a few stolen hours.

A week.

A week in a forgotten pocket of nowhere, sheltering in a hollowed cave mouth and the sparse cover of gnarled trees. Phainon caught rabbits. Built a fire. Told stupid, half-remembered village ghost stories, shared bruised, stolen fruit from a grove he swore the gods themselves had abandoned.

And Mydeimos had let him.

Listened.

Healed.

He remembered, with sickening clarity, how the ache in his leg dulled, but the ache in his chest only deepened. How every day he felt less like a prince, and more like a boy with no name.

And in the pale hours before dawn on the seventh day, Mydeimos left.

No farewell.

Just the heavy ache of something lodged behind his ribs.

He thought he'd never see him again.

And yet now—a lifetime later—here he was. The same maddening ease. The same damned smile.

Calling him little prince.

And Mydeimos, for all his iron will, all his discipline, still felt like that bloodied boy, pinned between shame and longing.

He loathed it.

He lived for it.

The evening had settled like a cloak, the sky caught in a wash of iron-blue and fading crimson. The statues of Nikador loomed tall between the flowers and olives, sword tips spearing through tangled branches. The scent of crushed earth and oil lamps clung to the air.

Mydeimos sat at the far end of a colonnade, one knee drawn up, his cloak discarded beside him. The waning light painted his profile in sharp planes —gaze fixed on nothing in particular.

Phainon hesitated.

He should leave him be. He knew that. Every instinct, every scrap of experience told him to turn around and quit while he was ahead. But he didn’t.

He crossed the stone path and came to a slow stop beside him, easing down.

A long silence stretched between them.

Phainon let out a small breath, offering a faint smile.

“Didn’t think you were the sentimental type, kid.”

At first, there was no reply.

Then—without turning—

“Stop calling me that.”

Phainon chuckled under his breath. “What, sentimental or kid? I’d say both fit.”

The change was subtle, but immediate.

Mydeimos shifted, straightening just enough to turn his head, gaze catching his.

And then he leaned in.

His voice, when it came, was quiet. Each word like a knife.

“I command armies. I bury men twice my age and twice my strength. I have bled, killed, and carved the names of my enemies into stone while you drank wine in Okhema’s shade.”

Phainon’s smile faltered.

“And you,” Mydeimos went on, his gaze sharp enough to flay skin, “still speak as if I’ve not earned the right to stand at your shoulder.

The words struck clean.

Phainon blinked, thrown for the first time in days. The warmth he wore like a second skin faltered, the ache of something colder settling in its place. He hadn’t expected— hadn’t seen—

“I…” Phainon swallowed, voice quieter now. “I didn’t know.”

No humor left in him.

“I didn’t mean it like that.”

Mydeimos said nothing, but the sharpness in his eyes dulled a fraction. Not softening. But easing the killing edge.

Phainon let out a breath, running a hand through his hair as he shook his head. “Alright,” he murmured. “No more ‘kid.’ You have my word.”

Mydeimos held his gaze a moment longer, then looked away.

Phainon exhaled, scrubbing a hand over his face.

“Right,” he muttered, mostly to himself.

Neither of them spoke.

The war god’s statue cast long shadows across the stone. A drumbeat from the city carried faintly on the wind.

Phainon stayed seated, though part of him itched to leave.

But he didn’t.

Mydeimos stood.

The movement was quiet, but it felt like the whole garden shifted with it.

Phainon glanced up, bracing for another cold dismissal, another silent wall.

Instead, Mydeimos spoke, leaving no room for argument.

“Fine. You’ve got yourself an audience. Tomorrow.”

He turned, pausing just long enough to glance back over his shoulder.

“Don’t disappoint me.”

And then he was gone. A shadow slipping between statues, swallowed by the fading light.

Phainon let out a slow, frayed breath.

Gods.

He sat there another moment, staring after the place where the prince had vanished.

Part of him knew he should scrap the plan. Cut his losses. Report back to Aglaea with nothing but bruised pride and an empty ledger.

But he wouldn’t.

One more shot.

One last chance, come dawn.

Then—whatever came after.

He sighed, hauling himself to his feet.

“Still alive,” he muttered to no one, and followed the garden path back toward the city lights.

Maybe he came a bit early.

Reasonable, really. Any sane man in his position would've done the same. It wasn't paranoia, per se—more like precaution. Because it wasn't entirely inconceivable that Crown Prince Mydeimos, in all his cold-blooded, ironclad unpredictability, might forgo the whole meeting on a whim. And then where would Phainon be? Back at Okhema with nothing but a spectacular personal failure and a lecture from Aglaea.

So yes—he came early.

Only a little.

The guards at the threshold had clearly not been briefed, judging by the way they'd straightened, exchanged brief glances, and began offering some practiced line about how the prince was not yet prepared to receive—

Phainon had cut them off with a sharp look. A few low, carefully chosen words. A comment about their prince's impeccable discipline, about how surely he wouldn't mind a guest of the Deliverer's… persistent reputation.

And a smile.

That had done it.

A shared, knowing look passed between the guards—equal parts pity and admiration, which was never a good sign—and then one of them had wordlessly led him inside.

Phainon followed, expecting stone walls and a council chamber. A war room maybe, lined with maps and iron-cast weapons. Or one of those blood-drenched shrines they called meeting halls.

What he got was… this.

Prince Mydeimos's personal quarters.

Dimly lit, heavy with incense, the kind of warm, quiet stillness that felt too intimate for what was supposed to be a political arrangement. And there—a figure reclined half-lazily on an overlarge, fur-draped bed. Long hair

unbound and spilling over his shoulder, bare skin catching the amber light. In one hand, a shallow cup, crimson liquid swirling slow and viscous.

Pomegranate. It had to be. Mydei hated wine.

Phainon swallowed.

He hadn't even known the prince was capable of *looking* like this. Lounging, half-naked, sharp-edged in the throat and wrist but somehow still softer in this setting but not quite. Like a sated lion still watching it's prey.

And then—Mydeimos spoke.

Voice low, heavy with sleep yet no less smooth.

"You seemed so eager to meet me." A lazy sip from the cup. Eyes half-lidded, unreadable. "Why so quiet now, Deliverer?"

Phainon did the only sensible thing a man in his situation could do.

He smiled tightly and lied.

"Didn't want to wake you."

"Mhm."

That was all the prince gave in reply. A soft, disinterested hum, neither agreement nor dismissal—but it was enough.

He straightened, cleared his throat. It was warm in here. Or maybe that was just his own pulse pounding a little too hard in his neck.

"Right—so, I… I won't waste your time," he started, already painfully aware that he probably was. "I came because—because this isn't just a visit."

Mydeimos sipped his drink, gaze fixed on him over the rim. Unblinking.

Phainon pressed on.

“I came because the Flame Chase Journey’s begun. You’d know that by now—all twelve Chrysos heirs tasked with—” he caught himself. Right, no need to explain what they both already knew. “And your name’s on that list.”

Nothing. Not even a flicker of surprise. Of course not.

“And I know there’s… controversy,” he pushed, words starting to tumble faster now. “Over what it means. Killing your own gods, claiming their Coreflames—I know Kremnos has ties to Nikador like no other nation. I understand why you’d hesitate. Why anyone would.”

He was rambling. He could hear it.

“But this isn’t just about that,” Phainon tried, forcing his voice steady. “It’s about what happens next. About what’s left after the Titans fall. Kremnos and Okhema are—we’re on fragile ground. The treaty is young, and no one trusts it’ll hold. You know that as well as I do.”

He took a step closer, hating how desperate it might look, but unwilling to stop.

“I believe if you join the Chase, if you stand beside us—it wouldn’t just strengthen your claim as a hero of your people. It would forge something lasting. Between our nations. Between you and the others. Between you and me.”

Gods, that sounded worse aloud.

Phainon faltered then, words catching in his throat as he stared at the prince’s face—a face that hadn’t changed once during his entire plea. Not a raised brow. Not a twitch of his mouth. Just that infuriatingly serene, detached expression.

He sipped his drink again. Waited.

Phainon felt his voice die out somewhere between his ribs.

Silence settled. Heavy. Long enough for the distant sound of the bloodfall to creep back into the edges of his awareness. Long enough for his own heartbeat to start sounding too loud.

And then, Mydeimos set his cup down. The soft *clink* was deafening in the quiet.

"This," the prince said, "is what you woke me up for?"

Not even anger in it. Just cold, flat disappointment.

Phainon swallowed.

Mydeimos stood.

Slowly. No sound but the shift of bare feet and the faint rustle of sheets.

Phainon tensed before he could help it, a lifetime of instinct making his shoulders square as if for a blow. The prince's drink sat abandoned on the low table now, forgotten.

"You're not used to being refused, are you?"

The words were soft, but they landed like a thrown dagger.

Phainon let out a breath through his nose, something wry curling at the corner of his mouth. *Who was?*

"Can't say I enjoy it," he admitted.

Mydeimos didn't answer. Just began circling him in, slow, measured steps.

The room felt too small all of a sudden.

Phainon stayed where he was, watching him sidelong. The tension in the air wasn't quite hostile. But it wasn't far from it either. This felt less like a conversation now and more like a fight waiting for a spark.

“If you want something from me, Deliverer,” Mydeimos murmured from behind him, voice pitched low, “you’ll have to earn it.”

Phainon turned, just enough to track him. “And how exactly would you have me do that?”

Mydeimos came to a stop a pace away, head tilting slightly. “Prove you can keep up.”

Phainon’s brow furrowed. That sounded a hell of a lot like—

His gaze flicked to the room. To the rumpled bed. The scattered weapons in the corner. The lack of armor on the prince’s frame.

“Here?” he asked, incredulous. “In your quarters?”

He gestured loosely. “You’re half asleep and half dressed, it’d be dishonorable to—”

“I don’t recall asking your permission,” Mydeimos cut in smoothly.

Phainon opened his mouth to argue, but the other man stepped closer, eyes gleaming faintly in the half-light. “Or,” Mydeimos drawled, “are you afraid?”

Damn it.

Phainon gave a quiet snort, shaking his head. “Fine, fine.” He reached up, shrugging off his outer coat with a fluid motion. The garment caught for a second on the chain around his throat—one of those simple, slender Kremnoan talismans he forgot he even wore—before sliding free.

He didn’t miss the way Mydeimos’s eyes caught on the motion. Or how, for a fraction of a second, his gaze lingered at Phainon’s bared neck before flicking away, face schooled back to perfect neutrality.

Strange.

Phainon flexed his knuckles, grinning despite himself. “Alright then, prince. But don’t cry when you lose.”

Mydeimos blinked.

Then, his mouth curved. Not a smirk, not a grin, but something sharper. A wolfish thing, all teeth and promise.

“Very well.”

That should’ve been his first warning.

They moved at the same time.

Phainon surged forward, aiming to end it quick—a sharp pivot and grab meant to get a hold around Mydeimos’s arm, twist him off-balance and prove a point without leaving a bruise.

But Mydeimos slipped past him like smoke, parrying the reach with a flick of his wrist and a sidestep that left Phainon catching air.

Not bad.

The prince didn’t follow up or press the advantage, just turned smoothly, watching him with that unreadable, half-lidded stare. Unbothered. Almost lazy.

But not careless.

Alright then.

Phainon went again. Faster this time. A feint, then a strike toward the shoulder. It was blocked easily, the sharp crack of wrist meeting wrist sounding in the stillness of the chamber. The force of it ran up Phainon’s arm.

He grinned.

And then they were moving, circling, testing the bounds of each other's footing. Neither going for a killing blow, but neither playing soft either. Mydeimos fought without wasted motion while Phainon fought with a relaxed, confident looseness.

At one point, Phainon ducked a sharp hook of Mydei's arm, rolling sideways and yanking down a thick curtain draped over the bedframe. The heavy fabric collapsed in a rush of sound between them, a wall of rich crimson that disrupted the prince's sightline for half a beat.

Phainon lunged through it—but Mydeimos was already moving.

The low table between them was kicked aside, narrowly missing Phainon's shin. The thing clattered to the floor and splintered against the far wall.

Titans.

"Hope that wasn't priceless," Phainon muttered under his breath.

They closed again, exchanging a quick flurry of blows—a jab, a block, a hook that caught Phainon's ribs hard enough to sting. He answered with a knee that nearly caught the prince's hip, only for Mydeimos to pivot away.

Evenly matched. Damn it.

Phainon stumbled back a step, bumping against one of the old wall hangings. He grabbed it for balance—and promptly ripped the thing down as Mydeimos advanced. The fabric coiled around his arm as he let it drop.

"Your interior decorator's going to hate me."

Mydeimos didn't so much as blink.

And then Phainon made his mistake.

He got cocky. That overconfident tilt to his shoulders as he feigned left and went low, sweeping his leg out in a move that worked on a hundred other men.

But Mydeimos wasn’t other men.

The prince caught the motion clean, stepped in with a sharp pivot, and used Phainon’s own momentum against him—seizing him by the arm and shoulder, slamming him hard against the cold stone wall.

A forearm pinned across his chest.

Phainon let out a grunt, blinking up into that impassive face a handspan from his own.

And then, despite himself, he chuckled.

“Titans,” he rasped, “you’ve gotten mean.”

Mydeimos didn’t answer. Just shoved him harder against the wall, the pressure sharp against his sternum, enough to remind Phainon who had the advantage.

His pulse thudded in his ears.

“What’s wrong,” he drawled, “afraid I’ll win next time?”

It was meant to be light—a needle to pry loose another one of those rare smiles.

But Mydeimos didn’t smile.

He let out a breath instead—a quiet, tight sound. Not quite a sigh or scoff. Almost…uncharacteristically soft, like he was tired of chasing a conversation only one of them knew they were having.

“You really don’t get it, do you?”

Phainon’s brow knit, confusion flickering there in the space between their locked gazes. “Get what?”

For a moment, nothing. No answer. Just the rasp of their breathing and the lingering heat of the fight. Mydeimos’s stare didn’t waver—but something

behind it faltered. The kind of fracture you almost didn't catch if you weren't already looking.

And Phainon was looking now.

Something about the set of Mydeimos's jaw, the slight tension in his mouth. His grip shifted minutely, like he wasn't sure whether to let go or hold tighter.

It should've ended there. A clipped insult, a sharp dismissal, the usual way these things went. But it didn't.

Instead, Mydeimos exhaled as if forcing down something long past bearing. His hand came up before Phainon could move, fingers curling at his jaw. Not hard or soft. Just… there.

Phainon stiffened, unprepared for the closeness. The warmth of that touch. The bare, unguarded weight of it.

"Mydei—"

"By Nikador's tenacity," the prince muttered, voice strained now, cracking at the edges, "you're so fucking slow."

And before Phainon could make sense of that—before the words even properly landed—Mydeimos kissed him.

It wasn't clean or careful. Just the sudden, certain press of Mydeimos's mouth against his—tense, restless, and so staggeringly *real* it cracked the world open.

Phainon froze.

His mind went hollow, all sharpness stripped away. No clever remark, no practiced deflection, nothing but a stunned, brittle stillness.

He felt the faint drag of Mydeimos's breath, the way the other man hesitated just a fraction too long, as if already regretting it, as if bracing for recoil.

Phainon’s fingers twitched at his sides. His heart kicked against his ribs.

What—

It didn’t fit. It clashed with every rule they’d been playing by, every look, every traded blow. And for a split second, his mind scrabbled for footing, for the shape of the world as it had been a moment ago—but it was already gone, slipping through his hands like sand.

He should pull away. Say something. Break it. Fix it.

He didn’t.

Because Kephale forgive him, there was a part of him—dazed and rattled and aching—that didn’t want to. Not yet.

And that was the first thing that truly terrified him.

They parted, barely.

Just enough space for breath. For the quiet, uneven hitch of it between them.

Phainon’s chest rose and fell, a sharp drag of air in his throat, the ghost of the kiss still clinging to his skin like heat after a burn. He stared, stunned in a way no blade or blow had ever managed.

“Mydei…” His voice cracked on it. He swallowed, tried again. “You—what the hell was—”

The words wouldn’t land. Wouldn’t form. They scattered at the edge of his tongue because he had never, not once, considered this. Not as a *possibility*, at least.

“Listen,” Phainon started, voice unsteady, trying to grasp for a scrap of solid ground. “Maybe you’re… I mean it was a fight, battle-rush, I get it—”

He didn’t get to finish.

Mydeimos's eyes snapped to him, and something in them broke. Not with the reserved aloofness Phainon was so used to reading there. This was him *pissed*. A nerve left bare too long.

"Don't," Mydeimos said. "Don't you dare reduce this to that."

Phainon froze.

And then it spilled out of Mydeimos, words stripped of grace or rank.

"I want you. Gods, I—" his jaw clenched. "I've wanted you for years. Since that cursed field you've long forgotten. Since every time you walked in and made it impossible to think straight."

"I tried to bury it. Smother it under duty, under war, under everything they told me a prince should be. It didn't work. It's never worked."

He let out a rough, uneven breath, dragging a hand through his hair, then met Phainon's eyes and said, *"It's you. It's always been you."*

The words hung there, a pulse between them.

And just as quickly as it came, Mydeimos stepped back, his face shuttering like a slammed door, only this time the cracks showed. A flicker of guilt. Of dread.

His voice, when it came again, was cool and formal—the practiced tone of a prince before a verdict.

"If you mean to mock me," Mydeimos said, quiet, though his hand flexed like it wanted to reach again and didn't, "go now. I won't be made a fool of. Not even by you."

Phainon's heartbeat was a hammer in his chest.

Every sane, rational part of him screamed to leave. To walk out of this room, this country, this madness before it pulled him under. He was meant to be responsible. The diplomat. The *guest*. A Chrysos heir with a nation's expectations balanced on his back.

Mydeimos let out a slow, almost weary sigh and turned away.

And that should've been the end of it.

It wasn't.

Phainon's hand moved before thought could catch it—a reckless motion, fingers curling tight around Mydeimos's wrist. He dragged him back in, hard enough to startle them both. Their mouths crashed together with nothing careful about it, rough and fevered, edged with too many years of restraint breaking in an instant.

Mydeimos froze for half a breath—just long enough for Phainon's stomach to twist—and then he surged forward, slamming him back against the stone with a force that rattled through his spine. One hand fisted in Phainon's toga, the other gripping his waist as if daring him to vanish again.

The kiss turned sharp, insistent. Tongue, teeth, a low sound caught somewhere in Mydeimos's throat as his leg shoved between Phainon's, bracing him there like a man long past reason. The taste of pomegranate, faint and tart, clung to the edge of it.

Phainon's thoughts scattered, useless now—nothing clear enough to make sense of this. Instinct carried him where reason refused. His hand slid up, fingers tangling in Mydeimos's hair, dragging him in harder, closer, until there was nothing between them but heat and breath.

The world outside the four walls of that room ceased to matter.

His brain was still screaming *what the fuck are we doing* even as his mouth chased another kiss. It wasn't going to work like this—too tall, too cramped, and his back already ached from the stone.

Breathless, flushed, he muttered against Mydeimos's mouth, "The bed, idiot."

For a second, Mydei just stared—pupils blown wide, chest rising hard. Then, without a word, he grabbed Phainon by the wrist, yanked him along,

and half-shoved him down onto the bed, following like he had no intention of letting go.

It unraveled fast after that.

Phainon's half-untied outfit slipping further with every breath, seams loosening. He barely noticed when the clasp came undone, too caught up in the press of Mydeimos's mouth at his throat.

The scrape of teeth over his pulse made him shudder, a sound catching in his throat.

"Mydei—"

A low hum against his skin, and then Mydeimos's voice. "Kremnoan colors have always suited you more."

It wasn't fair, the way that shot through him.

Phainon dragged him up for another kiss, mouths crashing, breath a mess between them. Every sane thought frayed at the edges. Instinct carried him forward—switching to press Mydei's back against the sheets, bracing on an elbow as his lips dragged along the line of Mydei's throat.

For a beat, Mydei let him.

A hitch of breath. A hand flexed at his waist. And yet—something about it felt off.

Phainon's hand faltered at Mydeimos's hip, throat working around the knot rising there.

"I… I should probably be the one to—" His voice cracked, an attempt at a smile pulling at his mouth. "I mean, you're—"

Younger. I don't want to push you. I should—

"Stop it."

Phainon froze.

Mydeimos reached up, fingers curling firm around his jaw, thumb brushing his cheek with a maddening kind of gentleness. His gaze caught him there.

“Trust me.”

That was it. The last thread snapped.

A sharp pull at his back, and then Mydeimos was moving—shifting his hips, claiming space, a mouth catching his in a kiss that left no room for argument. Teeth scraped, a low, guttural sound hummed against his lips, and Phainon barely kept up.

Then a leg hooked around his, dragged him down, and made it very, very clear where this was headed.

Phainon chased the heat of him like a fool and didn’t bother pretending otherwise.

He shifted against him, hips rolling in a slow, thoughtless drag. The friction of it made them both stutter—a ragged breath from Phainon, a sound from Mydeimos he probably hadn’t meant to let out.

Phainon gripped the leg hooked over his hip, fingers tightening in a wordless squeeze meant as reassurance, though for who, he wasn’t sure.

“I’ll… handle it,” he muttered, half under his breath, trying for a steady tone and failing. “Safer that way.”

He felt Mydeimos go still beneath him. Saw the way his throat worked around a swallow, pupils blown wide and black. The kind of look that could tear a man apart. Feral, and yet—almost shy, like he hadn’t planned for this part.

Phainon huffed a breath, dragged his gaze away and shifted upright, straddling him proper now. He worked his pants off one-handed—or what little of them was still hanging on—heat blooming up his throat at the weight of Mydei’s stare.

“Got any—?”

Mydeimos, visibly scrambling to remember how his hands worked, reached blindly to the side table. A small glass bottle clattered against the wood as he snatched it up and shoved it toward him, obviously on his last threads of composure.

Phainon let out a quiet, breathless laugh at that.

“Looks like someone came prepared.”

Mydeimos glared, but the pink rising under his skin gave him away.

Phainon slicked his fingers, jaw tight, skin burning in a way that had nothing to do with the fight. He averted his gaze, refusing to meet Mydeimos’s eyes as he settled astride him, one hand splayed over the hard line of Mydei’s chest for balance.

This was—

He pushed the first finger in, rough and too quick, more about getting through it than doing it right. The stretch made his breath catch. He stared hard at the far wall, teeth gritted against the way his body clenched.

The second slid in easier, and when it did, the soft, involuntary sound that broke out of him—a bitten-off groan—betrayed him. Phainon’s jaw locked, the burn at his cheeks threatening to swallow him whole.

His shoulders tensed, teeth sinking into his lower lip. Embarrassing. Fucking embarrassing.

Except then—he shifted his hand, angling instinctively, and when he brushed that spot—stars.

A sharp, involuntary sound broke out of him. His hips jerked down against his hand, breath catching hard.

Shit.

He tried to move through it even as he curled his fingers again and chased that jolt. The friction blurred into something worse as he thrusted deeper, stretching himself out. His thighs tensed, breath gone ragged, chest rising too fast.

He didn’t have to look to feel Mydeimos watching him.

But he did.

And when he did, it nearly undid him.

Mydeimos lay beneath him, utterly still, save for the tremble in his fingers where they dug into the sheets. His stare was ravenous—lips parted, throat working around a swallow like he was barely holding himself together.

It was obscene.

And then, as his fingers pressed deeper and that burst of pleasure shuddered through him again, Phainon couldn’t hold the sound back. A low, desperate moan broke out of him, his hips rocking down against his own hand.

Damn him. He was getting off on it.

He worked his fingers deeper. His hips rocked down, chasing the friction, low sounds slipping from his throat no matter how hard he tried to bite them back. Mydeimos beneath him was also unbearable—every twitch of muscle, every sharp inhale, the steady, impossible press of him against Phainon’s thigh growing harder by the moment.

He focused on the stretch, the ache sweetening into something else, lost in it now. One of his thighs trembled where it bracketed Mydei’s hips. Gods, he should ask—he should—

A hand closed over his wrist.

Phainon’s breath caught, his pace faltering. He glanced down, confused, lips parted to ask something—*What’s wrong?* or *Do you want me to stop?*—but the words never made it out.

Because in the next second, Mydeimos's grip tightened and forced Phainon's wrist down, driving his own fingers deeper with a rough, unexpected thrust.

A strangled moan punched out of Phainon, head dropping forward, his whole body jerking at the sudden pleasure. His other hand scrabbled at Mydei's shoulder for balance, heart hammering so hard it made him dizzy.

"Mydei—"

He didn't get the rest out.

Mydei moved fast, his restraint finally breaking. In one surge, he sat up, one arm bracing behind him on the bed while the other locked around Phainon's waist, dragging him in. Their chests nearly collided, breath mingling.

Phainon barely had time to register it before Mydeimos's hand slid between them again, curling around Phainon's wrist and guiding his fingers out—then shoving his own in without hesitation.

Phainon choked on a gasp, hips twitching, every nerve ending lighting up. Mydeimos's fingers were thicker, softer, and relentless. The angle sharper, the pace unforgiving.

The eye contact leveled him.

Mydeimos watched him like a man half-starved, lips slightly parted, the faintest tremor in his breath every time Phainon's face twisted around a moan. It was too much—and yet Phainon couldn't drag himself back. Couldn't stop the shameless sounds leaving his throat, the way his body rocked into every rough thrust of those fingers.

Mydeimos leaned back just enough to watch him, fingers still working deep, his other hand gripping Phainon's hip like he could hold him there forever. His eyes didn't move, locked on every twitch, every stifled sound Phainon made.

They worked rougher now, fucking into him without the caution Phainon had started with—desperate, unsteady, like every second he spent inside made it worse. The sounds of it filled the space between them, obscene.

Phainon's thighs quivered around his hips, breath ragged. He dragged his mouth along Mydei's throat, lazy and open-mouthed, teeth grazing skin just to hear the stuttered breath it pulled.

"You're…" Phainon half-laughed against his neck, sweat beading at his brow, voice wrecked. "You really are a beast."

Mydeimos didn't answer. If anything, his hand gripped tighter, the stretch sharper, pace messier now, like he was barely holding it together.

And then, in a sudden, unsteady motion, Mydeimos shifted, forcing Phainon back against the bed—his body following, looming over him, fingers never leaving him, pressing in deep as he settled between his legs. The position should've been a pause, a reset—it wasn't. Mydei's hand flexed, wrist working mercilessly inside him, the wet, slick sounds loud in the thick heat of the room.

Phainon's head tipped back, a rough moan tearing loose before he bit it down, eyes hazy. "Nikador," he swore, half laughing, half begging. "You're insane."

Mydeimos finally met his gaze, pupils dilated, sweat-slick hair clinging to his brow—and didn't deny a thing.

He finally pulled his fingers free, and the sharp, sudden emptiness made Phainon's hips twitch involuntarily—a frustrated noise slipping past his lips before he could catch it.

He barely had time to miss it before Mydei was shoving down his last piece of clothing, freeing his cock—thick, flushed dark, heavy against his stomach. And then he reached for Phainon again, one hand curling around his thigh, the other guiding himself to the slick heat between his legs.

Phainon was fine. Relaxed, loose-limbed and ready to mouth off—until he glanced down.

And promptly choked on his own spit.

His brain short-circuited. Gods. *Gods*. That was… no one should be built like that. It was objectively unfair. It made his own—which wasn't modest by any means—feel like a cruel joke.

He must've tensed without meaning to, because Mydei's stilled, gaze flicking up to him in silent question.

Phainon cleared his throat, awkward, feeling absurdly warm. "I— uh… I just… well, I don't know if I can take you."

The words hung between them. Phainon braced for some solemn vow, or a cautious retreat, but what he got instead was a sudden, sharp exhale—and a soft laugh.

It floored him.

The sound was unexpected, like it had been dragged out against Mydei's will, but it was warm in a way Phainon had never heard from him. It made something in his chest clench.

His first thought: *He's got a beautiful laugh.*

His second: *What the fuck is he laughing at?*

Before he could snap something defensive, Mydeimos shook his head, that same small smile tugging at his mouth as he grabbed Phainon's thighs and pushed them wider, leaning in close.

"Don't worry," he murmured, voice confident. "I know you can."

And with that, he pushed the thick, aching head of his cock inside—a stretch so sharp Phainon bit down hard on his lower lip, head tipping back with a ragged moan as his whole body arched.

He wasn’t sure when he stopped breathing.

Mydeimos pushed in slow—too slow and somehow not slow enough. The head alone felt impossibly thick, forcing its way past muscle already stretched from fingers, but this was different.

His nails dug into Mydei’s shoulders before trailing lower, down the broad expanse of his back, gripping wherever he could, teeth clenched hard.

“Titans—” he gasped, eyes squeezed shut, panting through it. “Are you—are you all the way—?”

“Not yet,” came the strained answer.

Mydeimos was shaking with control. Phainon could feel it—the tension in the hands braced on either side of him, the way he exhaled slow and ragged like he was holding back from slamming all the way in. His hips rocked in slow, shallow thrusts, easing in inch by devastating inch.

Phainon tried to breathe again. Failed.

He could feel every vein dragging inside him. Every throb.

His head dropped back against the pillows as he clung tighter, legs tightening reflexively around Mydei’s waist. It burned in a way that made his eyes water from sheer, aching fullness. Every time Mydei shifted, something deeper lit up inside him—some coil of nerves that made his whole body tense and then melt all over again.

“Still—?” he choked. “You’re still not in—?”

“Almost,” Mydei managed, voice hoarse now. “You’re… tight.”

A helpless sound clawed its way out of Phainon’s throat. He couldn’t even bite it back this time—he was too focused on staying present, on breathing through it, on not collapsing just from the pressure.

One more roll of Mydei’s hips and Phainon swore as he felt his spine curl. He gasped, chest heaving, fingers clawing at sweaty skin. Mydei dropped

his head to kiss just below his ear, whispering through grit teeth, “Almost there. You’re taking me so well.”

Phainon swallowed hard, hips twitching involuntarily.

And then, with one final slow push, Mydeimos sank all the way in.

Phainon’s mouth dropped open, no sound at first—just a shaky exhale as his whole body clenched around the thick weight seated deep inside him. He felt impossibly full, stretched in a way that blurred thought.

He didn’t say anything for a long second. Just breathed, shallow and fast, heart hammering as Mydei held still.

“…That’s all of you?” he asked eventually, voice barely there.

Mydei only nodded, forehead resting against his.

“Yeah.” A pause. “That’s all.”

Phainon let out a breathless, disbelieving laugh—dazed, flushed, and still somehow gripping his shoulders like the ground might drop out from under him.

Mydei moved again—shallow, testing thrusts that still managed to make Phainon gasp, his body jolting with every careful slide. It was an unbearable fullness, each push dragging over hypersensitive flesh that made his thighs tremble around Mydei’s hips.

Phainon’s hand scrabbled for something to hold, catching on Mydei’s shoulder, his neck, anywhere. He pressed his face against Mydei’s throat, letting out a breathless groan against his skin.

“You—oh—”

Mydei didn’t answer.

Another thrust, this one deeper. Phainon choked on a noise, teeth catching his lip hard. It was too much and somehow not enough.

He didn’t realize he was covering his face with one hand, arm thrown over his eyes, until Mydei stilled. A hand moved, fingers wrapping tight around his wrist. Phainon blinked, surprised, and then Mydei was dragging his hand down, pinning it against the bed beside his head.

“Look at me.”

A demand.

Phainon hesitated, chest rising and falling hard, but met his gaze.

Mydei’s pupils were dark, almost swallowing the gold of his irises, lips wet and parted. His fingers twitching against Phainon’s skin like he didn’t trust himself to move without snapping

“Tell me what I am to you now.”

It wasn’t a question. Just a rough prompt, landing sharper than it should’ve. Phainon opened his mouth. Closed it.

For a long second, he just *looked* at him.

At the confidence in his grip, the calm set of his mouth, the way his eyes never left him. No boy, no ghost. A man—tempered, self-possessed, and carrying more weight in his silence than a hundred shouted declarations.

And Phainon, for the first time, let himself *see it.*

His throat worked. Something stubborn cracked apart in his chest.

Phainon huffed out a breath, slumping down against him, one arm looping around Mydei’s neck like it hadn’t taken years to reach this point. “You win, Mydei.” he muttered, not a trace of fight in it.

And then, without thinking, his legs tightened.

Strong thighs flexing, wrapping around Mydei’s waist and hauling him flush, forcing him deeper. Both of them groaned—Phainon’s head tipping back, Mydei’s jaw clenching as he swore under his breath.

The smirk came slow. Sweat-dampened lips curling just enough to make Mydeimos twitch, eyes flickering like he'd been hit in the gut.

"Well," Phainon managed, voice a teasing murmur, "don't hold back now."

Something dark flickered through Mydei's face. His cock twitched inside him, and Phainon felt it—eyes widening slightly because maybe that wasn't the smartest thing he could've said.

"Your funeral," Mydei grumbled.

The thrust made Phainon jolt—a sharp, wet sound of impact filling the space between them. A pulse of heat seared up his spine, his back arching instinctively, a gasp wrenched from his throat before he could catch it. It wasn't just the stretch—gods, though it burned—it was the sheer relentlessness of it. Mydei didn't ease in, didn't pause to let him adjust. He was chasing something now, something old and ugly and starved.

And Phainon felt every bit of it.

Fingers clawed into Mydei's shoulders, blunt nails dragging down sweat-slick skin as his legs tightened again, breath ragged.

"Fuck—"

Another thrust, just as deep, grinding against that spot that made Phainon see white behind his eyelids. His mouth fell open, soundless at first—then a wrecked moan he barely recognized as his own.

And then he heard Mydei's voice—low, barely more than a breath against his ear. "There it is."

The next thrust hit the same spot, and Phainon broke, head tipping back, throat bare. A bead of sweat slipped down his neck.

Mydei's hand slid to his jaw, forcing him to face him— the flush on his face nothing compared to the desperate, maddening restraint in the tight line of his mouth. His gaze dropped to Phainon's lips, then lower, drinking him in like a dying man finally allowed to taste.

“If you’d looked at me like this before,” he murmured, “I’d have lost whatever was left of my reason.”

It was the kind of thing you said once, cutting through whatever was left of Phainon’s practiced ease.

His stomach clenched at the words, something sour and sweet twisting together in his gut.

Another push. Mydei ground in hard enough to make Phainon’s toes curl, his body arching up into it, a sound he didn’t mean to make catching in his throat.

“Fucking hell,” Phainon hissed, sweat-slicked, eyes half-lidded.

His cock throbbed against his stomach, the wet slap of skin dirty in the otherwise quiet room—save for Mydei’s ragged breaths and the scrape of his teeth against Phainon’s collarbone.

The pace picked up. Each thrust a little sharper, a little deeper, hitting that same aching spot again and again until Phainon was trembling, his grip on Mydei’s back slipping.

And then—against his jaw:

“I’m not stopping,” Mydei said as if reading his mind, a promise.

Phainon’s throat worked. The pressure built, relentlessly, like his whole body was on fire.

“Good,” Phainon rasped, his voice catching, legs tightening again, a reflex he couldn’t fight. His body ached, stretched wide around him, but he didn’t care. Couldn’t. Every time Mydei bottomed out inside him, it punched the air from his lungs and he wanted more.

“Harder,” Phainon gasped, his shamelessness now a weapon. “Come on, prince. Is this it? You can do better.”

Mydei’s jaw flexed.

“You should hold your tongue,” Mydei managed, though his next thrust betrayed him—harder enough to make Phainon’s vision swim.

“Never,” Phainon grinned, lips flushed, eyes glassy with sweat-slick hunger. “What would you chase then?”

And gods—the look Mydei gave him then. Like a man willing to burn for it.

Without another word, Mydei’s hand slid under one thigh, hitching Phainon’s leg higher, the new angle making both of them groan. His mouth latched onto Phainon’s throat, kissing, biting, leaving marks like a man cataloging every inch of him. And still, the pace held— the head of his cock battering that same bundle of nerves until Phainon’s toes curled and his breath hitched, stars dotting his vision.

Somewhere in it, tears stung the corners of his eyes.

“Faster,” Phainon begged, his voice thick, broken open. “Right there—Titans, don’t stop.”

And Mydei, half-mad, groaned against his skin. “I won’t,” he promised again. “Not till you beg me to.”

And Phainon, feeling reckless—smiled through the ache. “Then you’ll be here a while.”

The next thrust stole what was left of his words.

Time blurred.

Phainon lost track of how many times he came. At some point, it stopped mattering. Whether it was from Mydei’s hand around him, his mouth, or untouched, it all bled together.

He wasn’t sure if he ever fully stopped shaking. Wasn’t sure if the wetness between them was sweat or something else, only that his skin burned where

Mydei touched him—palms dragging over his waist, his ribs, the side of his throat. He'd buried his face in the curve of Mydei's neck somewhere after the third or fourth time, the world tilting.

Mydei's pace never really slowed. If anything, it grew sharper, heavier, carrying a kind of desperate edge that made Phainon's chest clench every time the other groaned into his hair—reverent, like prayer.

Somewhere in the mess of it, Mydei started cursing.

Not in common, but in his native tongue. Words that meant nothing to Phainon but sounded sweet when they fell from his lips, rough and almost tender, like they were meant for no one else.

Phainon had slurred things too. Affectionate, filthy nonsense between ragged moans, words half-meant, half-laughed against sweat-slick skin. Called Mydei beautiful, relentless, his favorite person in the world. Told him he was perfect, that he felt too good, that no one else could ever touch him like this. Whispered promises he'd forget by morning and mean anyway. It earned him shudders, the bite of teeth at his throat, another brutal thrust that made him sob out a sound he wouldn't remember.

The room reeked of sex. Time pulled thin. Every nerve frayed, pleasure folding in on itself until Phainon didn't know if he was still begging or just breathing.

He knew only the feel of Mydei—the pulse of his cock inside, the bruising grip on his hips like he couldn't bear to let go.

And then—now.

A pause. Mydei's breath ragged against his ear, the rhythm faltering for the first time in what felt like hours. Phainon was limp against him, skin tacky, eyes half-lidded, his head lolling slightly on Mydei's shoulder as the prince's cock throbbed deep inside.

A stammered curse. The telltale tension in Mydei's hips, the way his fingers clenched like he meant to pull away.

And without lifting his head, without even opening his eyes, Phainon let out a lazy murmur—a hand curling weakly at the back of Mydei's neck.

"Inside," he muttered. Not a plea. Not even a request. Just a simple, unbothered order.

Mydei froze.

A sharp breath.

And then a shuddering groan—Mydei snapping forward, driving in to the hilt. The sound he made when he came was ragged, torn from somewhere deep. Phainon felt it in the way Mydei's whole body trembled against him, and without meaning to, it pulled a smug, fucked-out smile to his lips.

Would've been a waste not to.

Mydei stayed buried deep for a moment longer, forehead pressed to Phainon's shoulder, the rise and fall of his chest stirring the hair at Phainon's neck. Neither moved. Neither spoke.

Then—a shallow exhale, and Mydei finally pulled back.

Phainon made a frustrated noise at the loss, a faint furrow tugging between his brows as the emptiness ached sharp and sudden, his body clenching uselessly around nothing. He felt the slow, slick warmth of it trailing down his thigh. Unfair.

He didn't open his eyes, but the displeasure was obvious.

Mydei slumped beside him, the weight of his body solid and grounding. He leaned in, head resting against Phainon's chest, his breath still coming in uneven pulls as though he hadn't quite caught up to himself yet.

Phainon let out a breath of his own—half a laugh, rough around the edges. His fingers drifted up, threading lazily through sweat-damp hair, combing it back from Mydei's temple.

"Nikador's mercy," he rasped, voice amused, "you're dangerous."

A low, almost abashed sound left Mydei. Not quite a laugh. More a huff as he pressed his face into the crook of Phainon's neck like he could hide there, the sharpness of earlier lost to something softer, and deeply unguarded.

Phainon's hand stayed in his hair, fingertips tracing the nape of his neck, a quiet fondness bleeding through every idle pass.

It was Phainon who broke the hush, his voice quieter now, but honest in a way he rarely let slip.

"I didn't realize you… saw me like that."

Mydei didn't answer at first. But he shifted, pushing upright enough to put space between them, as though about to say something. Whatever it was didn't come.

Phainon didn't let him go far.

His arm shot out, looping around Mydei's waist, a firm pull that yanked him back in with a warning squeeze. Not harsh, but inarguable. A clear message: don't run.

Before Mydei could protest, Phainon buried his face in his chest, letting out a content, almost smug-sounding sigh against warm skin.

Mydei let out a besieged, bone-deep sigh of his own, one hand coming up to card through Phainon's hair, and muttered under his breath, "Pervert."

He didn't move away.

Phainon felt the words coil in his throat before he could stop them. He huffed a breath, tilting his head to glance up at the ceiling for a beat, then dropped his gaze to the man against him.

"I'm serious," he said, voice softer than it had been all night. "I was thinking… maybe you and I could—I don't know. Try something."

A pause. His lips quirked. "Assuming you want to."

Mydei snorted.

A full, unimpressed, *are-you-fucking-kidding-me* sound from deep in his chest. He didn't even lift his head, just let it rumble out against Phainon's shoulder like the sheer stupidity of the question was too much effort to address properly.

Phainon chuckled despite himself, dragging Mydei in closer by the waist, shifting until he was half-sprawled on top of him again, propped up on one elbow. He looked down, eyes crinkling.

"Really?" he teased, thumb brushing along Mydei's jaw. "Even though your people hate me?"

At that, Mydei stiffened—a flicker of something ghosting over his face, his mouth tightening, though not at Phainon.

"It's been two years," Mydei muttered at last. "They don't hate you. The wounds… haven't all closed. That's different."

His hand moved then, a slow, absent drag from Phainon's hip up along the curve of his waist—lazy, possessive, the kind of touch that made Phainon's skin prickle in its wake. Mydei's gaze flicked up, something amused behind it, but his tone stayed quiet, almost idle.

"Though if you really want to tour again," he murmured, fingers tightening just slightly at Phainon's waist, enough to make him feel it, "I'll make sure they behave."

That shouldn't have made Phainon shudder—but it did.

He laughed, ducking his head to bite lightly at Mydei's shoulder in retaliation before shifting the topic with a sly, "Well—"

The grin tugging at the corner of his mouth betraying how unserious the question was—but he asked it anyway.

"What about your parents?" he asked, fingertips lazily tracing along Mydei's jaw, brushing the damp hair away from his temple. "Pretty sure

they actually do hate me."

Mydei gave a sound that might've been a laugh if it wasn't so dry. He shifted, one arm tightening loosely around Phainon's waist.

"They hate more people than they love," he said. "If they didn't glare at you, I'd be worried."

Phainon barked a laugh at that, hand moving to cup Mydei's cheek. "Really?" he teased, though a flicker of memory surfaced—of Queen Gorgo's cold, measuring stare, King Eurypon's unreadable expression like a man already imagining how best to dismantle him in four different ways. He visibly shivered, though he tried to pass it off as nothing.

"Actually… you know what?" he muttered. "Maybe this is a bad idea."

He didn't mean it. But damn if it wasn't a little intimidating.

Mydei's eye twitched, and he shifted just enough to level a look at him.

"They'll treat you with the respect you deserve," he said solemnly, not even being a question.

Phainon's pulse caught for half a second. It was stupid, how fast his heart kicked up at that—but it did.

And then the humor in his expression faded, just a touch. He exhaled, the air leaving him, thumb stroking once against Mydei's cheekbone.

"There's one thing though," he said, quieter now.

Phainon traced idle circles along Mydei's spine, the earlier heat softened into something looser. He could've stayed like this—half-draped over the other man, the world held at arm's length.

But it wasn't his to hold off forever.

He sighed.

And Mydei must’ve felt it, because his hand stilled where it rested against Phainon’s hip. A brief pause. Then, a quiet exhale, less annoyed than resigned. When he moved, it was slow, straightening slightly, the loose sprawl of limbs tightening as he gathered himself.

His face sobered, the warmth bleeding out of his expression by degrees—not cold, but composed. The Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos once more.

He met Phainon’s gaze, unreadable as ever.

“Speak, Deliverer.”

Not a lover now. The war-forged heir, who carried his nation’s name like a blade.

Phainon swallowed.

He should’ve prepared for this moment. Rehearsed it. Worn one of his strategic smiles and let it carry him through like it always did. But maybe it was the hour, or the ache in his bones, or what they’d just done—but he didn’t have it in him to be anything but honest.

“I could tell you it’s for the whole of Amphoreus,” Phainon sighed. “For everyone and their safety. That if you join us, you’ll be securing peace for generations.”

A pause. He let his hand drop to the sheets, staring at the folds between them like they held answers.

“But the truth is… it’s for me too.”

He didn’t glance up. Couldn’t. Not yet.

“I don’t know if I’m enough for this,” he admitted. “If I can carry it alone. If I even want to anymore.”

A bitter laugh scraped out of him. “I’m supposed to be the Deliverer. I was born with a prophecy wrapped around my throat and meant to carry the weight of the world on my back. But sometimes, gods, I wake up and all I

want is to leave it behind. Burn the prophecy. Disappear. Let someone else bleed for it."

The words felt heavier spoken aloud than they ever had in his head.

"And I've never… I don't ask for things, Mydei. Not like this." He finally looked up, meeting the other man's gaze.

No titles now.

"I'm not asking as the Deliverer. Or the Chrysos Heir."

He drew a breath.

"I'm asking as me."

Another beat, the night stretching long and silent between them.

"Come with me."

An invitation.

And for the first time in a long time, Phainon let himself hope.

Mydeimos didn't answer right away.

He sat there, eyes on Phainon like he was weighing every word, testing them for fractures.

Then, finally—a slow exhale through his nose.

"I'll consider it."

Simple. But it meant something, coming from him.

His gaze softened, just barely. "Sleep, Phainon. We'll speak in the morning."

Phainon huffed a tired laugh, everything finally catching up to him at once. He let his head drop back to the pillow, every muscle gone loose and spent.

“Didn’t know you could order a man to sleep,” Phainon mumbled, his voice already exhausted.

Mydei didn’t bother replying. Just stayed where he was, one arm draped heavy across Phainon’s waist, his gaze somewhere distant.

The room settled with the soft drag of breath, and the faint cooling of sweat-damp skin.

Phainon’s lashes fluttered. Sleep pulled at him slow, like tide against shore.

And just as the dark started to take him, something brushed his ear—low, quiet, meant for no one but the night.

“There’s little I wouldn’t do for you.”

A warmth in his chest, a tug at his heart.

Phainon smiled, eyes already shut.

Darkness took him.

The sun poured warm and golden through the open arches of the chamber, bathing the marble floor of Okhema’s hall in light. Scrolls lay unrolled across the polished table, ink still fresh on the latest decree.

Aglaea stood at its head, one hand poised on the carved edge, eyes skimming the official seal of Kremnos pressed in crimson wax beside their own.

“A formal alliance,” she murmured aloud, voice smooth but carrying a sharp, pleased undercurrent. “The Crown Prince of Kremnos joins the Flame Chase Journey, and with him, his nation’s full protection over Okhema until its conclusion. A declaration of unity, binding in fire and blood.”

She let the words settle, a small, knowing smile curving the corner of her mouth.

“Well, Phainon,” Aglaea said without lifting her gaze from the parchment, “I would ask how you managed it, but I think I’d rather hear you admit it.”

Phainon, lounging far too casually in a chair nearby with a bottle of wine, choked.

Spluttering, he set the cup down too fast and avoided her gaze. A flush rose to his face, trailing from his cheeks to the tips of his ears.

“I—” He cleared his throat. “I earned it.”

Aglaea’s brow arched.

At that moment, Cipher passed through the chamber toying with a coin, glancing between them. She grimaced, sighing as if physically pained.

“I’m not getting that outfit back, am I?”

Phainon elbowed her in passing without a word, his face still pink.

Aglaea let the moment linger, savoring it like fine wine before setting the parchment down with deliberate grace.

“Remind me to commission a temple in your honor, should we live to see the end of this madness,” she mused, voice rich with dry amusement.

Phainon groaned, rubbing a hand down his face. “Terrible idea.”

Without missing a step, Cipher’s voice drifted from the corridor. “I’ll start on the statue.”

A ripple of irreverent laughter stirred the air, light as sunlight against stone.

End Notes

Hmm I think this and day 5 are my longest ones? Dunno, but hey ty for reading and sticking to the end <333333

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